

# 8 Diagnosis Lines That Ward Doctors Use, in Plain English

Eight lines for the moment you have to explain a diagnosis to someone who is frightened. These are not vocabulary words. They are the exact sentences a senior doctor uses, in the order they use them.

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## The eight phrases

The same eight lines, now with the pronunciation and the reason each one works. Listen, then say each out loud.

1/8

### Tell me what you have been told so far.

/tɛl mi: wɒt ju: hæv bi:n təʊld səʊ fɑ:/

FINDING OUT WHERE TO START

**INSTEAD OF** Has anyone explained this to you?

**Why it works.** A yes or no question gets you a yes. This one gets you her words. Now you know where to start, and which words she already has.

*Before I start, tell me what you have been told so far.*

Sabihin po ninyo sa akin kung ano na ang nasabi sa inyo.

2/8

## I am afraid I have some bad news.

/aɪ æm ə'freɪd aɪ hæv sʌm bæd nju:z/

WARNING BEFORE THE NEWS

**INSTEAD OF** So, the results are back.

**Why it works.** The warning buys you three seconds. In those seconds they stop, and they start listening properly. News with no warning is often not heard at all.

*Please, have a seat. I am afraid I have some bad news.*

Pasensya na po. May hindi po magandang balita ako.

3/8

## Here is what that means for her.

/hɪə ɪz wɒt ðæt mi:nz fɔ: hɜ:/

TURNING THE FINDING INTO WHAT CHANGES

**INSTEAD OF** The results indicate a significant abnormality.

**Why it works.** A name is not news. What changes for her is the news. Say the change first, and the name has somewhere to sit.

*That is the medical name. Here is what that means for her this week.*

Ito po ang ibig sabihin niyan para sa kanya.

4/8

## I am going to stop there for a moment.

/aɪ æm 'gəʊɪŋ tuː stɒp ðeə fɔːr ə 'məʊmənt/

LEAVING A SILENCE ON PURPOSE

**INSTEAD OF** So the next step is a referral, and then we'll book the clinic.

**Why it works.** After hard news, people stop hearing for a while. Silence is not an empty space. It is the time they need to catch up.

*I am going to stop there for a moment. Take your time.*

Titigil po muna ako sandali.

5/8

## I do not know yet, and I will tell you when I do.

/aɪ duː nɒt nəʊ jət ænd aɪ wɪl tel juː wɛn aɪ duː/

SAYING YOU DO NOT KNOW

**INSTEAD OF** Let's not worry about that yet.

**Why it works.** Let's not worry sounds like bad news you are hiding. The plain truth is easier to carry. A promise to come back is worth more than a comfortable answer.

*I do not know yet, and I will tell you the day I do.*

Hindi ko pa po alam, at sasabihin ko po sa inyo kapag alam ko na.

6/8

## Which part would you like me to go over again?

/wɪtʃ pɑ:t wʊd ju: laɪk mi: tu: gəʊ 'əʊvər ə'ɡen/

INVITING THE HARD QUESTION

**INSTEAD OF** Do you have any questions?

**Why it works.** Do you have any questions asks her to admit she did not follow. This one puts the fault on the explanation, not on her. That is the version a frightened person will actually answer.

*Which part would you like me to go over again? I can say it a different way.*

Aling bahagi po ang gusto ninyong ulitin ko?

7/8

## Tell me how you would explain this at home.

/tɛl mi: haʊ ju: wʊd ɪk'spleɪn ðɪs æt həʊm/

CHECKING THEY HAVE IT

**INSTEAD OF** Does that make sense?

**Why it works.** A frightened person nods. A nod is not understanding. Ask them to explain it to someone else, and you hear what they really have.

*I want to be sure I have explained this well. Tell me how you would explain it at home tonight.*

Sabihin po ninyo kung paano ninyo ito ipapaliwanag sa bahay.

8/8

## I am going to write it down, so you have it tonight.

/aɪ æm 'gəʊɪŋ tu: raɪt ɪt daʊn səʊ ju: hæv ɪt tə'naɪt/

GIVING THEM SOMETHING TO KEEP

**INSTEAD OF** It'll all be in the letter.

**Why it works.** The letter comes next week. She has to say this tonight. Written down, the word is hers to keep, and she can show it to whoever asks her.

*I am going to write it down, so you have it tonight, with the number to ring.*

Isusulat ko po ito para may hawak po kayo mamayang gabi.

## The steps

This is the sequence. It does not change.



### Find • Warn • Say • Check

Four steps. If you remember nothing else today, remember that order. Someone who is warned, told what it means and then asked to say it back walks out holding the same news you gave them.

## Now you produce it

Write your answer first, then compare. Retrieving the phrase from a situation is what moves it into the language you can actually use under pressure. There is more than one right answer.

**1. You are about to start. You do not know what she has already been told.**

**Tell me what you have been told so far.**

A yes or no question gets you a yes. This one gets you her words. Now you know where to start, and which words she already has.

**2. You have the results in front of you and she is watching your face.**

**I am afraid I have some bad news.**

The warning buys you three seconds. In those seconds they stop, and they start listening properly. News with no warning is often not heard at all.

**3. You have said the medical name. It means nothing to her yet.**

**Here is what that means for her.**

A name is not news. What changes for her is the news. Say the change first, and the name has somewhere to sit.

**4. You have just said the hard sentence. She has gone completely quiet.**

**I am going to stop there for a moment.**

After hard news, people stop hearing for a while. Silence is not an empty space. It is the time they need to catch up.

**5. She asks whether her mother will be all right, and you do not know.**

**I do not know yet, and I will tell you when I do.**

Let's not worry sounds like bad news you are hiding. The plain truth is easier to carry. A promise to come back is worth more than a comfortable answer.

**6. She says she has no questions. You can see that she has.**

**Which part would you like me to go over again?**

Do you have any questions asks her to admit she did not follow. This one puts the fault on the explanation, not on her. That is the version a frightened person will actually answer.

**7.** She is nodding at everything. You need to know what she actually has.

**Tell me how you would explain this at home.**

A frightened person nods. A nod is not understanding. Ask them to explain it to someone else, and you hear what they really have.

**8.** She is standing up to leave with one new word to carry.

**I am going to write it down, so you have it tonight.**

The letter comes next week. She has to say this tonight. Written down, the word is hers to keep, and she can show it to whoever asks her.

## Come back to this

Two situations, on the two days the research says matter. Say the phrase out loud before you look at the list again.

### **3**/day **Day 3**

*Three days ago you learned the four steps: find, warn, say, check. New situation. You have five minutes rather than twenty, and the person in front of you is angry rather than frightened. Which of the four steps do people drop first under that pressure, and which sentence would you make sure you still said?*

### **7**/day **Day 7**

*One week in. This is the one people get wrong. The person you are explaining to keeps saying she does not want to be any trouble, and she agrees with everything you say. Two lines from this lesson still work here. Can you remember which, and how you would use them without sounding as if you are testing her?*

